Part 4: Tie-Breaking Essay

These notes are not intended to be understood as a key for the Tie-Breaking Essay prompt; rather, they should serve the judge(s) as a presentation of critical ideas that might appear in an essay responding to the prompt.

Criteria for judging the Tie-Breaking Essay **SHOULD** include

the degree to which the instructions have been followed,

the quality of the critical insight offered in response to the selection,

the overall effectiveness of the written discussion, and

the grammatical correctness of the essay.

Note well that the quality of the contestant's critical insight is more important than the contestant's prose style. In short, the Literary Criticism contest is one that promotes the critical analysis of literature. The quality of the writing, which should never go unappreciated, does not trump evidence of critical analysis.

Critical Notes on Robert Browning's "Misconceptions"

Literary concepts that **MIGHT** be used in a discussion of the misreads in Browning's "Misconception" include

alliteration,
analogue,
assonance,
consonance,
feminine rhyme,
imagery,
implied action,
masculine rhyme,
metaphor,
run-on line,
rhyme scheme,
tenor,
tone, and
vehicle.

The contestant should recognize immediately that the poem's title yokes the two stanzas in what is essentially **not** a comparison but a single set of comparisons. The first stanza offers an example from nature; the second stanza moves closer to the human realm in which the persona "wanders" (line 13), elevating the woman, who would be charmed by the persona's attention, to the level of Queen. Both comparisons (here, metaphors without an expressed tenor) address the manner in which the persona establishes a relationship and then wanders quickly on, perhaps to the next relationship.

Browning's lyric poem explores the psychology of someone who points, seemingly without compunction, to short-lived relationships in which the women apparently expect commitment: the spray "blossom[s] with pleasure," but **his** commitment is a "hope beyond measure"; the Queen's heart is "thrilled in a minute erratic"; however, it is her "fancy [imagination] ecstatic" that has set up an expectation not to be met.

It is the psychological aspect of Browning's first-person "Misconceptions" to which the contestant who has spent time with the dramatic monologues will be drawn. He or she might note the persona's brazen denial of responsibility in the lines pointed out above: "hope beyond measure" and "fancy ecstatic."